

ORAKZAI TRIBAL GENEALOGY

“Tracing the traditional lineage while separating genealogy from historical proof.”

Tradition Lineage Structure Evidence Memory

Genealogy is one of the oldest ways communities organize memory. For Pashtun societies, genealogical traditions have often provided a framework for describing relationships between tribes, sections, lineages, and families.

The Orakzai are traditionally placed within the wider Karlani branch of Pashtun genealogy. But a genealogy is more than a list of names; it preserves ideas about belonging, kinship, political relationships, and collective identity. At the same time, a genealogical tradition should not automatically be treated as a scientifically verified biological family tree extending into the distant past. This distinction is essential to understanding Orakzai genealogy responsibly.¹²



“Traditional genealogical classification framework within Pashtun society.”

THE KARLAN, KODI, AND KAKI TRADITIONS

In traditional accounts, such as those discussed in historical genealogical literature and chroniclers like Nī’mat Allāh al-Harawī in the *Makhzan-i Afghānī*, the Karlani tribes are often

traced back to Karlan. According to traditional genealogical sub-branchings, Karlan's descendants are divided into branches including Kodi and Kaki, with Orakzai traditionally positioned under the Kodi lineage. However, modern scholarship treats these accounts as traditional frameworks rather than proven chronological histories.¹²



“Traditional genealogical branching showing the placement of Orakzai under the Kodi lineage.”

MAJOR ORAKZAI SECTIONS AND LINEAGES

Historical and administrative records, such as those compiled in British Frontier gazetteers and ethnographic surveys, document the traditional organization of the Orakzai into major sections (Taps). These sections reflect geographic distribution, political alliances, and social organization across the Mastura and Khanki valleys.⁴⁵



Plus Sturi Khel, Ali Khel, and associated Hamsaya clans (Malla Khel, Mishtis, Sheikhans).

“Documented major traditional sections and clans of the Orakzai community.”

TRADITIONAL GENEALOGY ≠ GENETIC PROOF

Genealogy records social and cultural memory; genetics investigate biological populations.

“Maintaining critical distinction between genealogical memory and biological evidence.”

RESPONSIBLE FAMILY GENEALOGY

Moving from the tribal scale to the family scale, genealogical research requires rigorous methodology. A responsible family tree distinguishes between verified documentary evidence, reported family traditions, and unverified links. Preserving oral accounts from elders while maintaining intellectual honesty prevents the accidental fabrication of historical ancestry.³

✓ KNOWN (Documented)

? UNCERTAIN (Reported)

○ UNVERIFIED (Traditional)

“Classification standards for responsible genealogical record-keeping.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

When I look at a genealogy, I do not see only names connected by lines. I see generations trying to remember where they came from. Some names are supported by documents, some survive through the voices of elders, some are repeated because they have been carried through tradition, and some remain uncertain. I believe the honest genealogy is not the one with the

most names. It is the one that tells us which names we know, which names we inherited, and which questions remain unanswered. For an Orakzai, understanding genealogy should therefore be an act of respect—not an excuse to turn tradition into unquestionable history.

“A family tree is not only a record of descent. It is a record of memory.”

AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS
